

Do We Love Shadows?

PLATO'S ALLEGORY OF THE CAVE

Vocabulary Preview

- **Allegory:** A story whose details point to a deeper meaning.
- **Enlightened:** Brought into clearer understanding or truth.
- **Illusion:** Something false or misleading that seems real.
- **Reality:** What truly is, not merely what appears to be.
- **Ascent:** A climb upward; here, the soul's movement toward truth.
- **Dazzled:** Blinded or overwhelmed by sudden brightness.
- **Compelled:** Forced, pressed, or strongly required to act.
- **Intellectual:** Having to do with understanding and reason.
- **The Good:** For Plato, the highest truth, source of reason and right order.
- **Conversion:** A turning around; here, the turning of the whole soul.
- **Contemplation:** Careful, steady thought about what is true.
- **Virtue:** Excellence of character; moral and intellectual goodness.

Introduction

Plato was a Greek philosopher who lived in Athens from about 428 to 348 B.C. In *Republic*, he uses the voice of Socrates to ask what justice is, what kind of city is best, and what kind of education forms a good human being. The Allegory of the Cave appears in Book VII, after Socrates has been discussing knowledge, appearance, and the Form of the Good.

This passage is not mainly about learning facts. It is about what happens when a person is turned away from comfortable appearances and toward reality. Plato imagines education as painful, disorienting, and sometimes dangerous. As you read, ask: **Why might someone prefer shadows to truth?**

Source note: Adapted and modernized from Plato, *Republic*, Book VII, 514a–520a, in Benjamin Jowett's public-domain translation. This version preserves the passage's sequence, dialogue structure, images, and main claims while using modern student-facing English.

Reading

1. The Prisoners and the Shadows

"And now," Socrates said, "let me show you an image of our nature when it is educated and when it is not educated.

"Imagine human beings living in an underground cave. The cave has an opening toward the light, but the prisoners are deep inside it. They have been there since childhood. Their legs and necks are chained so that they cannot move around or turn their heads. They can only look straight ahead at the wall in front of them.

"Behind them, higher up and at a distance, a fire is burning. Between the fire and the prisoners there is a raised path. Along that path stands a low wall, like the screen used by puppeteers when they show puppets above it."

"I see," said Glaucon.

"Now imagine people passing along that wall," Socrates continued, "carrying all kinds of objects: vessels, statues, and figures of animals made of wood, stone, and other materials. The objects appear over the wall. Some of the carriers speak; others are silent."

"You have shown me a strange image," Glaucon said, "and strange prisoners."

"They are like us," Socrates replied. "What do the prisoners see? They see only their own shadows, and the shadows of one another, thrown by the fire onto the wall opposite them."

"That must be true," Glaucon said. "How could they see anything else if they have never been allowed to move their heads?"

"And of the objects being carried behind them," Socrates said, "they would see only the shadows."

"Yes."

"If they could speak with one another, wouldn't they think they were naming the very things they saw in front of them?"

"Certainly."

"And suppose the prison had an echo from the wall. When one of the people walking behind them spoke, wouldn't the prisoners think the voice came from the passing shadow?"

"No question."

"Then to them," Socrates said, "the truth would be nothing but the shadows of the images."

"That is certain," Glaucon replied.

2. The First Pain of Being Freed

"Now consider what would naturally happen if the prisoners were released and cured of their error.

"Suppose one of them were suddenly freed. He

is forced to stand up, turn his neck, walk, and look toward the light. All of this would hurt. The glare would distress him, and he would be unable to see clearly the real objects whose shadows he had seen before.

"Then suppose someone told him, 'What you saw before was an illusion. Now you are nearer to what is real, and because your eye is turned toward more real things, you see more truly.' What would he say? And if his instructor pointed to the passing objects and required him to name them, would he not be confused? Would he not think that the shadows he formerly saw were truer than the objects now being shown to him?"

"Far truer," Glaucon said.

"And if he were forced to look straight at the firelight, wouldn't his eyes hurt? Wouldn't he turn away and run back toward the things he could see, thinking that those were clearer than the things now shown to him?"

"True," Glaucon said.

3. The Ascent into the Light

"Suppose next," Socrates said, "that someone dragged him away from the cave by force, up a steep and rough ascent, and would not let him go until he had been pulled into the sunlight. Wouldn't he be in pain and angry at being dragged? And when he came into the light, wouldn't his eyes be so dazzled that he could not see any of the things now called real?"

"Not all at once," Glaucon said.

"He would need time to grow accustomed to the upper world. At first he would see shadows best. Then he would see reflections of people and other things in water. After that he would see the things themselves. Then he would look at the light of the moon, the stars, and the sky by night more easily than at the sun and sunlight by day.

"Last of all, he would be able to look at the sun itself, not merely at its reflection in water or somewhere else, but at the sun in its own place. He would be able to contemplate it as it is."

"Certainly."

"Then he would reason about the sun. He would understand that it produces the seasons and the years, governs all things in the visible world, and is in a certain way the cause of everything he and his fellow prisoners used to see only dimly."

"Clearly," Glaucon said. "First he would see the sun, and then he would reason about it."

4. Remembering the Cave

"When he remembered his old dwelling place, the wisdom of the cave, and his fellow prisoners, do you think he would rejoice in his change and pity them?"

"Certainly."

"And if the prisoners had honors among themselves, praising the person who was quickest to observe the passing shadows, who best remembered which shadows came before, which came after, and which appeared together, and who could best predict what would come next—do you think the freed man would care for those honors? Would he envy the people who held power among the prisoners?"

"Or would he agree with Homer that it is better to be a poor servant of a poor master, and endure anything, than to think as they think and live as they live?"

"I think," Glaucon said, "that he would rather suffer anything than hold those false opinions and live in that miserable way."

5. The Return to the Cave

"Now imagine that this same man comes suddenly out of the sunlight and is put back into his old place in the cave. Wouldn't his eyes be full of darkness?"

"Of course."

"And suppose there were a contest, and he had to compete again with the prisoners who had never left the cave, judging the shadows before his eyes had adjusted to the darkness. He would look ridiculous. The prisoners would say that he went up and came back with ruined eyes.

They would say it was not worth even trying to go upward.

"And if someone tried to free another prisoner and lead him up to the light, wouldn't they seize that person, if they could, and put him to death?"

"No question," Glaucon said.

6. What the Allegory Means

"This whole image," Socrates said, "must now be joined to what we said earlier. The prison house is the visible world. The firelight inside it is like the power of the sun. The journey upward is the ascent of the soul into the intellectual world.

"Whether this is exactly right, only God knows. But this is my opinion: in the world of knowledge, the Form of the Good appears last of all and is seen only with effort. Once it is seen, we understand that it is the author of all beautiful and right things. In the visible world, it produces light and the lord of light. In the intellectual world, it is the source of reason and truth. Anyone who would act wisely, either in private life or in public life, must keep his eye fixed on this."

"I agree," Glaucon said, "as far as I am able to understand you."

"Then you should not be surprised," Socrates continued, "that those who reach this vision are unwilling to return to ordinary human affairs. Their souls are always hastening toward the upper world, where they desire to remain. That desire is natural, if our allegory can be trusted.

"Nor should you be surprised if someone who passes from divine contemplation back into the troubled affairs of human beings seems awkward and ridiculous. His eyes are still blinking. Before he has grown used to the surrounding darkness, he may be forced to argue in law courts or other places about the images of justice, or even the shadows of those images, against people who have never seen justice itself."

"That is not surprising at all," Glaucon replied.

"Anyone with sense," Socrates said, "will re-

member that the eyes can be confused in two ways and for two opposite reasons. A person may be confused when moving from light into darkness, or when moving from darkness into light. The same is true of the mind's eye.

"So when he sees a soul whose vision is weak and confused, he will not laugh too quickly. First he will ask: Has this soul come from a brighter life and become unable to see because it is unused to the dark? Or has it turned from darkness toward the day and become dazzled by too much light? He will count the first soul happy and pity the second. And if he laughs at the soul coming upward from darkness into light, that laughter makes more sense than laughing at the soul returning from the light into the cave."

"That is a very just distinction," Glaucon said.

7. Education as Turning the Soul

"If this is true," Socrates said, "then certain teachers of education are wrong. They say they can put knowledge into the soul when it was not there before, as if they were putting sight into blind eyes."

"They do say that," Glaucon replied.

"But our argument shows that the power and capacity for learning are already present in the soul. The eye cannot turn from darkness to light unless the whole body turns. In the same way, the instrument of knowledge cannot turn from the world of becoming to the world of being unless the whole soul is turned. By degrees, it learns to endure the sight of what truly is, and finally the brightest and best of what is: the Good."

"Very true."

"Therefore there must be an art of conversion: an art that turns the soul around as easily and effectively as possible. It does not put sight into the soul, because sight is already there. The problem is that the soul is facing the wrong direction and looking away from the truth."

"Yes," Glaucon said. "Such an art seems possible."

8. Why the Educated Must Return

"It follows," Socrates said, "that neither the uneducated, who have no experience of truth, nor those who are allowed to spend their whole lives in study without ever returning, will be good rulers of a city. The first group has no single aim to guide public and private life. The second group will not want to act at all; they will think they are already living apart in the islands of the blessed."

"Therefore the founders of the city must compel the best minds to rise toward the knowledge we called greatest. They must ascend until they reach the Good. But when they have ascended and seen enough, we must not allow them to remain there."

"What do you mean?" Glaucon asked.

"I mean that they must return to the prisoners in the cave. They must share the labors and honors of the cave, whether those honors are worth having or not."

"But isn't that unjust?" Glaucon asked. "Would we be giving them a worse life when they could have a better one?"

"You have forgotten," Socrates answered, "that the law does not aim to make one class in the city especially happy while ignoring the rest. It aims at the happiness of the whole city. It holds the citizens together by persuasion and necessity, making them benefit one another. It produces such people not so each may please himself, but so each may help bind the city together."

"True," Glaucon said. "I had forgotten."

"Then there is no injustice in requiring the philosophers to care for others. We will say to them: In other cities, people like you grow up by themselves, and it is reasonable that they owe nothing to a government that did not educate them. But we educated you to be rulers for yourselves and for the other citizens. You are better prepared than others for both duties."

"So each of you, when his turn comes, must go down into the common dwelling place of the cave and get used to seeing in the dark. Once you

have acquired that habit, you will see far better than the people who live there. You will know what the images are and what they represent, because you have seen the beautiful, the just, and the good in their truth.

"Then our city will be a reality and not only a dream. It will not be governed like cities where men fight one another over shadows and struggle for power as if power were the greatest good. The truth is that the city whose rulers are least eager to rule will be the best and most quietly governed; the city whose rulers are most eager to rule will be the worst."

"Quite true," Glaucon said.

Reading Focus

1. Underline one sentence showing that the prisoners mistake appearance for reality.
2. Circle one moment where truth or education causes pain.
3. Put a star beside one place where the freed prisoner sees more clearly than before.
4. Write "resistance" in the margin beside the moment when the cave-dwellers reject the person who tries to free them.
5. Box one sentence that explains what education really is for Plato.

Window Note

Create a three-pane window note. In the first pane, draw the prisoners watching shadows. In the second, draw the freed prisoner being turned or dragged toward the light. In the third, draw the freed prisoner returning to the cave. Under each pane, write one sentence explaining what that scene shows about truth, comfort, education, or resistance.

Claim Building

Answer in one clear paragraph: **Why might someone prefer shadows to truth?** State a claim, use one specific moment from Plato's allegory, explain how the evidence supports your claim, and end by connecting the idea to education.

Comparison Seed

Keep this sentence for later readings: **For Plato, people resist truth because _____.** As the unit continues, test whether Bacon, Augustine, Douglass, and Newman agree with Plato or give a different explanation.